



SID MEIER'S CIVILIZATION IV

"It's turn-based? How does a turn-based strategy game get billed as one of the greatest games of all time? What is this world coming to?" I bellowed, scepticism oozing out of every pore. By the time I was old enough to know what the *Civilization* series was all about, I felt a marked disinclination to try it out. Curiosity, however, still kills cats everywhere.

In The End, There Can Be Only One

Sid Meier's *Civilization IV* (Civ 4), like all *Civilizations* before it, is all about building your empire by making it grow, and by conquering

other empires. Sounds like them all? It's not that simple. To keep your city growing, you need to keep your people happy—a few beefy guards to keep them safe, a regular supply of food, and some culture to keep the city's borders growing, and your people won't rebel against you.

You start out as the leader of a civilisation—from Napoleon leading the French or Roosevelt leading the Americans to Julius Caesar leading the Romans, or even Gandhi leading the Indians. It's really fun when your people talk back to you (sometimes curtly, too) in Hindi.

Everybody starts out in the prehistory of man, and your

civilisations develop and evolve. Through your explorations of the world, you encounter other rulers who you can decide to be friends or enemies with, open up trade routes, and throw a friendly insult at every once in a while. You eventually reach futuristic times, with the capability to nuke each other left, right and centre.

And now for the part I dreaded the most—you have to play in turns. So you issue a command to each of your units in your turn, and wait for other civilisations to make their moves. If you haven't played turn-based strategies before, this can be more than a little frustrating, but after a while, it's not so bad.

